

NOSKOVA CZECH-MATES MUCHOVA IN THRILLING FINAL

Minutes after Linda Noskova squandered five championship points and lost the second set of the Wimbledon final, she walked through the All England Club for a short break. She spotted the Venus Rosewater Dish and stared at what was once so near yet now seemed so far away.

Asked what she was then thinking, after her riveting 6-2, 5-7, 6-3 final victory, Noskova told *ESPN*, "I'm going to get that trophy no matter what."

Karolina Muchova (**right**), her good friend and Olympics doubles partner, had seized the momentum in what was the first Wimbledon final for both. Noskova admitted, "My hand kind of froze at the end of the second set. I have never been in such a situation. The pressure was definitely on. I just had to reset and tell myself that I can do this all over again in the third set."

Would Noskova, a 100-1 long shot, falter under the pressure as her compatriot Jana Novotna did in the 1993 Wimbledon final after blowing a championship point against Steffi Graf? Or, even worse, suffer the complete meltdown that befell nerve-stricken Amanda Anisimova when she was shut out by Iga Swiatek in the 2025 Big W final?

Neither, as it turned out. Noskova's sound strokes and power game — likened to that of former No. 1 Lindsay Davenport — regained the potency that had given her a 6-2, 5-2 lead before she made the classic mistake of taking her foot off the gas and letting her opponent back into the match. Muchova smartly capitalised on the lapse with aggressive forehands and low-bouncing slice backhands.

Noskova looked shaky in the critical opening game of the deciding set but managed to save two break points with forehand winners. The tide turned for good in the next game when she broke Muchova's serve for a 2-0 lead.

In the next game, Noskova faced her last crisis. Muchova fashioned a backhand passing-shot winner for

break point and pumped her fist.

Noskova grabbed the next three points, including a forehand winner, to take a 3-0 advantage. With Noskova serving at 3-1, 15-love, Muchova hit a tweener off a terrific Noskova lob, but it was to no avail. Noskova finished off the point with a forehand winner and then held serve for 4-1. At 5-3, 15-all, Noskova wrapped up her first Grand Slam title with a crosscourt forehand winner, a 110-mph ace up the middle, and an explosive first serve that ricocheted off Muchova's racket.

In a victory gesture of joy, relief, and perhaps some disbelief, Noskova collapsed on her back and

put her hands over her face. When she got up, she smiled broadly, embraced Muchova, and then sat down and covered her head with a towel to perhaps process her life-changing triumph. Then, as the crowd applauded and cheered some more, she climbed into the stands to hug her father, coach, and others in her player box.

Despite the disappointing loss, Muchova didn't lose her sense of humour during the trophy presentation, which featured Her Royal Highness Catherine, Princess of Wales. Fighting off some tears, Muchova quipped, "It's tough to find any words, but I'll start with Linda,



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